COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Go-To-Market and Operations Leader at Airbnb Believes AI Agents Are Transforming the Online Travel Industry

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OTHER COMPANIES

META

SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview discusses the company's strategic response to the rise of AI personal agents, including internal AI development, customer support transformation, and the broader shift toward a super app model. It also covers the impact of AI agents on demand aggregation, marketing, and the evolving competitive landscape for online travel platforms.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Leads monetization and go-to-market strategy for new verticals at a major travel platform, focusing on AI transformation and agentic commerce; previously worked on e-commerce and agentic commerce at TikTok Shop.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Believes **the rise of AI personal agents poses both a significant threat and opportunity, particularly in disrupting traditional demand aggregation and discoverability models**.
- Expresses **caution in opening the platform to external AI agents**, preferring to build proprietary solutions to maintain control and protect core business economics.
- Views the transition to a super app and AI-centric future as essential for long-term competitiveness, but acknowledges the complexity and **risks** involved.

TAKEAWAYS

- The company is in the midst of a major AI transformation, aiming to launch its own proprietary AI agent by 2027 and currently restricts access to external AI agents on its platform.
- A hybrid approach is used for customer support, combining in-house AI solutions with select external vendors like Decagon and Twilio, but not Sierra or ElevenLabs.
- There has been a significant increase in low-intent, pre-booking inquiries due to AI agents, but this has not translated into higher conversions; post-booking and post-check-in remain the most critical stages for customer support intervention.
- **The company is expanding beyond vacation rentals into hotels**, experiences, services, and transportation, with the goal of offering a seamless, end-to-end travel booking journey within one platform.
- AI agents are seen as a disruptive force to traditional SEO/SEM-driven demand aggregation, prompting the company and other OTAs to explore business-to-agent capabilities and new protocols to remain relevant.

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Expert Bio

Go-To-Market and Operations, New Verticals at Airbnb. The expert can speak to the strategic considerations behind personal AI agent development, including Airbnb's decision to launch a proprietary personal AI assistant. Additionally, the expert can speak to the evolving relationship between personal AI agents and customer service platforms, as well as market positioning against traditional online travel agencies, with an emphasis on reduced reliance on traditional search engine marketing and search engine optimization. Go-To-Market and

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Operations, New Verticals at Airbnb. Reporting to the Head of New Verticals, the expert is responsible for expanding business beyond core accommodations across APAC, driven by AI transformation across Services, Transportation, and Trips. Prior to Airbnb, the expert was the Vertical Partnerships Lead, TikTok GO at TikTok, leaving in March 2026. Reporting to the Regional Director, the expert was responsible for leading global online travel agency onboarding, managing commercial, contractual, and connectivity partnerships, and driving ad monetisation across travel and super-app verticals. The expert can speak to APAC market expansion, travel tech partnerships, GTM strategy, AI operations, ad monetisation, and super-app revenue scaling. They are also experienced with partner integrations, including Traveloka, tiket.com, Klook, KKday, Viator, Tripadvisor, GetYourGuide, Tiqets, Expedia, Headout, Musement, and Groupon.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Thanks for taking the time. By way of background, we are doing research on personal agents and wanted to speak with you just to better understand the impact that's having at Airbnb. But maybe before we go into specific questions on that, it would be helpful if you could just give me a bit more detail on your background and role at the company, and then we'll go from there.

Expert 00:00:22

Yeah, of course. Specifically for this project, I have been leading the monetization teams for Airbnb as we go through this big AI transformation from being just a vacation rentals platform into a travel super app. As part of that, we are then dealing with AI agents and agentic commerce and the whole transformation behind that. I've had a fortunate front-row seat around some of those initiatives and monetization strategies, which I hope I can be of help to.

If you are interested as well, my experience in TikTok, just before this, also involved a bit of agentic commerce as well. Maybe slightly different, but looking at your project brief, which was towards consumer marketplaces, my role was in TikTok Shop, so I can speak about e-commerce a little bit if you are interested as well.

Client 00:01:12

Got it. I may want to revisit TikTok Shop later in the call, but maybe we will start just with impact and work at Airbnb and just what you guys are doing from a strategy perspective with personal agents.

Expert 00:01:27

Was that a question for me?

Client 00:01:28

Yeah. Question, just to start. Top down, can you outline the strategy around how you guys are thinking about personal agents at Airbnb, whether you want to build stuff internally ,native into the app versus integrating with platforms like Instinct, Muse, and others?

Expert 00:01:47

Sorry, I thought that was a statement. I can speak about it as well. As we are going through this transformation, I would say we are in the middle of the transformation, not early, not late, but in the middle. Two weeks ago, our CEO, Brian Chesky, came out and committed that we are going to build our own AI agent, and it will be ready by 2027. We will be building our own proprietary technology. At the moment, AI agents like Instinct, Muse, are restricted on the Airbnb website or Airbnb platform.

This is quite common among OTAs within the travel industry at the moment, as everyone's seeding out what these AI agents are doing and what their functions are, and also as Airbnb creates their own strategy around building that AI agent. On the top line, we are building our own AI agent, and at the moment, we are restricting access from external AI agents, from sourcing and scraping the platform.

Client 00:02:48

Do you mind if we go a bit deeper on the rationale as to why you guys are restricting these personal agent platforms today, just given their user growth and virality?

Expert 00:02:59

Yeah. I think it's a wider conversation in travel as well, in terms of travel versus, say, food delivery, it's a lot more aspirational and discoverable and very emotional decision. Versus if you were to buy or order something on DoorDash, which is obviously a lot more transactional and a decision that can be made within minutes rather than days and weeks. We have not felt confident to open up the floodgates to allow these AI agents to come in. Also because bear in mind for OTAs and platform like Airbnb, we don't really own the supply. We are an asset-light company, and the discoverability factor of Airbnb, through SEO, SEM, and other different methods around Google,

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which was obviously a lot more towards pre-AI.

We still are quite heavily dependent on those as we navigate this uncertain time. At the moment, we have not opened up the floodgates for the AI agents until we get a lot more clarity. Of course, as I mentioned two weeks ago, we are now committed to building our own AI agent, which we also have, as I am sure your research has told you, Brian Chesky has invested and is building an AI lab, **which is obviously a lot more uncommon among travel marketplaces or e-commerce marketplaces**.

If you talk to other experts from, say, Booking.com or Expedia, but we have our own AI lab internally as well, and that's why **we are also beefing** up our AI capabilities and hence why we feel confident to then build our own AI agent come 2027.

Client 00:04:32

Got it. Is the restrictions on the OTA perspective because you guys do not want to cede economics to a Muse or an Instinct today? Is that largely the rationale? Ultimately, these personal agents may be a substitution effect versus a consumer manually searching on Google, on ChatGPT or another platform and relegating some of that discovery to their agents.

Expert 00:04:56

Yeah. I think **all OTAs feel particularly vulnerable at this time**. You mentioned earlier, OTAs have historically created enormous value by solving search and comparison. Those AI agents that you mentioned with Instinct and Muse can potentially make search and comparison almost invisible. We are already seeing it with ChatGPT, with Claude, with the first wave of AI agents or AI assistance agents coming in, say about 12-18 months ago. Obviously now you have advertising, monetization on all these GPT and LLM platforms. **I think the biggest disruption** potentially occurs at the front where the personal agent already knows where you like to travel, your budget, preferred locations, any loyalty programs, requirements, group sizes, and stuff like that.

OTAs, I think traditionally, when you look at AI, when you look at all these different movements and technological changes, we are always a quarter or two behind the consumer tech platforms like food delivery, e-commerce because we are obviously dealing with a lot more higher value bookings. Like I said, the decision behind buying travel is very different from buying, say, something that you need for your home on an e-commerce platform like Amazon. Yeah, that's where we are at right now.

Client 00:06:15

Got it. You said you were also working on new monetization levers for Airbnb earlier in the call. Can you maybe just walk me through what that means as it relates to personal agents?

Expert 00:06:27

Yeah, no, that's a good point. As part of the whole personal agents conversation, it's also then made **it complicated for us** because since late last year, we are now moving into a super app. As you know, Airbnb has always been known for a platform to book homes, vacation rentals, apartments, wherever you want to travel around the world. Essentially now we are adding hotels, we are adding experiences, services, transportation, and all this has come on board within the last six to 12 months.

On top of us dealing with the AI transformation, on top of us dealing with AI agents and trying to build an AI agent strategy for 2026 and 2027, we also have to make sure that **we don't compromise our core business**, which is vacation rentals, but at the same time, invest in our non-core businesses that I mentioned earlier, where it's more towards experiences, hotels, services, flights. Essentially what will happen then in 2027 is we want to come to a point where we say, okay, Mr. John is traveling from New York to London for his business trip or leisure trip within one platform and within one travel journey or travel booking journey with our own, obviously proprietary AI agent as well.

We want to make sure that we know Mr. John's requirements and we are able to book him a trip from him leaving his apartment in New York to him getting back to New York after one week from his business or leisure trip. That's the whole idea of us then launching these new businesses on top of also then transforming the company towards more AI-centric future.

Client 00:08:02

Got it. From a post-purchase experience for customers or like a post-booking experience, what do you guys use for customer support today? How are you thinking about that strategy from an agentic shift?

Expert 00:08:15

Yeah, great question. Up until about six to nine months ago, we were very much around human customer service. A lot of our customer service was answered by actual humans, and we didn't really have a chatbot, and we were one of the latest to come in. We were quite late with a chatbot. I think we were just waiting to see what's out there in the market. The start of this year, **we launched a chatbot for post-booking inquiries and also transformed completely our customer service journey by introducing our AI customer service and**

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providing a lot more resources and a lot more faster response times to guests who were stranded or who needed help. Not guests, but also the host and the suppliers themselves. We have it both ways.

We are dealing with the customers, but we are also dealing with the homeowners who are providing these homes. Now fast-forward to today, which is nine months later, we have a hybridized model where we segment host and guests based on their use cases. If, let's say, a guest has some trouble, for example, they couldn't check in, or they were harassed at an apartment, or even for the host where the guest has left the apartment in such a mess or caused damage, we provide them with very specialized customer service routes, which initially would be AI-driven. If, let's say, it qualifies to be something very serious and violates our policy and community policies, then it will reach a human, and that's the hybridized model that I mentioned earlier.

Client 00:09:42

Got it. Are you working with a software vendor to provide that solution, or did you build this agentic customer service journey all in-house?

Expert 00:09:52

It's, again, another answer from me. You will get a lot of hybridized answers from me today. To your latest question, it's hybridized as well. I would say 60% of it was built in-house, and then 40% of it was built using external software, AI labs. This is public information I can share with you, but we used Twilio. Twilio is obviously more of a communication provider as a service. We use them more for making sure our communication with the guest or the host was able to be done not only via airbnb.com, but if they wanted to use WhatsApp or iMessage or SMS, in which part of the world they were at, those communication was possible.

We used a couple of vendors that were part of the tech stack, but I would say that agentic customer support would be majority built in-house by Airbnb.

Client 00:10:44

Got it. Do you work with Decagon, Sierra, or ElevenLabs on this aspect or is it only infra providers?

Expert 00:10:52

ElevenLabs, no. We actually evaluated them, but we felt that they were not suitable for our use case. Sierra, we also evaluated them, but we didn't quite use them. Decagon, we are using them. Decagon is something that we are using, since about six to nine months ago, up until when we launched this particular agentic customer support that I mentioned earlier, where we changed the way we approach customer service. Decagon is something that we use as part of the tech stack, but not Sierra and not ElevenLabs.

Client 00:11:27

Got it. As **you see the rise of the personal agents on the demand side**, I would presume, how do you think about personal agent protocols then connecting into your customer support agents, and what trends are you seeing from a volume perspective there?

Expert 00:11:43

Are you referring to pre-booking or post-booking or both?

Client 00:11:46

Both. I would be curious across the booking journey from discovery to booking to onsite experience. Where did you typically see the most amount of customer inquiries or host inquiries? How has that changed with the result of personal agents, and how are you guys thinking about responding to that to handle that level of volume?

Expert 00:12:07

Now, that's a good question. Let me answer it in two angles. You rightly mentioned we have to look at it from a customer's perspective, but also a host perspective. Since we launched this hybridized model, we are seeing a lot more, I wouldn't want to call the word unwanted traffic, but it's low-intent traffic for the pre-booking stage, where people are then more comfortable with just spamming questions and asking very random questions where you can actually find it on our help article. Pre-booking has definitely risen, and **we've unfortunately** not seen that same rise in conversion, even though the inquiries are coming in. Pre-booking doesn't really change much in terms of payment issues and all that kind of stuff.

What happens is when they do a post-booking or post-check-in, that's when the issues start to come up, and that's when we start to see a lot of the AI agents and a lot of the customer support getting deployed in various different use cases. We are seeing how can we optimize that and make that journey better. For example, with Airbnb, I think you also must have seen in your market research, **one of the biggest**

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issues that we have is we don't have a uniform way of classifying customer service or in terms of escalation or issues. If you think about booking an Airbnb versus booking a hotel, with a hotel there is a concierge at level one at the lobby, **you can obviously troubleshoot your issues**.

With Airbnb, you don't have a host, or you have a host that may help you to troubleshoot the issues, but a lot of the times these hosts are not actually at the property, and they are just using an automated lockbox remotely somewhere else. you are actually looking at a lot of the inquiries and questions coming in when it's post check-in, when the guest has actually checked into an apartment or to a home. That's where we see how can we deploy our agents the best and make sure that **we answer as many questions as possible and touch base with as many guests as possible without compromising the journey or causing any cancellations or refunds that may happen as a result**.

That's how we are thinking about from the customer side and how do **we battle that** and ensure that, number one, at the inquiry stage, we increase the number of conversions and stop the noise coming in from low-intent traffic, but also at the same time for the post-booking and post-check-in piece, how can we standardize this piece and make sure that the escalations that do need to happen to go to a human get actually rerouted to a human, and then the rest of them can actually be answered from automated perspective? All of this in one bucket. We do have very high safety protocols.

Just for your information as well, on Airbnb, all bookings are insured. You don't have to pay an additional insurance fee or anything of that sort. If anything goes wrong, Airbnb is liable, and we will then provide you payments and stuff like that. Of course, from a financial perspective, we want to make sure that throughout the entire journey, it's safe, it's insured, it's proper, so that **we are not incurring financial losses on us**. That's on the first part of it, which is the customer side of things. On the host side of things, it's pretty straightforward. Hosts are very engaged in the platform. They know what they are doing. They know how to list a home, a product, or an apartment or a room on Airbnb.

The issue comes where it's similar with post check-in or post booking as well, where there is a bad review or there is an unfair review, or where there is something that they feel that happened, and they need to claim a certain damage amount because the guest might have wrecked the sofa or the living room, or may have conducted a party without their permission when they actually have house rules that do not allow for a house party. Those kind of things obviously come in when it is post-booking and post check-in.

We try to obviously then reroute that accordingly, as I mentioned to you earlier, is what we do for customers, and ensure that we do it in a safe environment. Even for hosts as well, they are also insured. We are taking that liability from both the customer and the host side of things. We need to ensure that that is done safely and in a proper environment so that **we don't incur financial losses on the company**.

Client 00:16:27

Got it. Are you guys allowing personal agents to ping and engage with your customer support agents in this process?

Expert 00:16:34

Not at the moment.

Client 00:16:36

If an Instinct tries to call you on behalf of their host to file a claim for damages, for a recent stay at their property, you would block an incoming call from an Instinct?

Expert 00:16:46

That's an interesting question. I can tell you right now, **Muse is completely blocked** because of certain safety regulations. I am not a safety or privacy expert, but from what I know, a lot of e-commerce marketplaces have blocked Muse at the moment. I think Amazon is the biggest one that have come out publicly and said. We, I think, follow that same stance as well. Instinct is not banned, it's not restricted, but there is no rule to not completely disallow them. If an AI agent were to call through, I don't think that AI agent would be rejected. However, we are putting in safety controls to ensure that **we do not just receive calls or inquiries from AI agents or rogue AI agents**.

We want to make sure that we are working with proper companies who have safety controls in place. At the moment, I believe if you use Instinct AI and try to search something on Airbnb and try to book something on Airbnb, it will allow you to go to a certain stage, but there are certain functionalities where it doesn't allow you to do it. Obviously, a human has to take over and make that call himself.

Client 00:17:52

Got it. Is there anything else we haven't talked about that you think would be helpful for us to know as we are doing work in this space?

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Expert 00:18:02

If I can ask, what is the purpose of your market research? What are you trying to find exactly? I prepared quite a bit of topics, but I am just wanting to make sure that it is relevant for what you are trying to find out.

Client 00:18:15

We are looking at the rise of personal agents and the impact it's having on the discoverability layer. We are looking at it in terms of the impact it's having on the transaction and payment layers and where economics through, and we are looking at it on the post-booking or post-customer service layer. Impact personal agents will have to a Sierra, a Decagon, ElevenLabs. Does it make **those companies more valuable or less valuable to triage and respond to your point, the low traffic volume** that a lot of these agents are driving today versus having humans respond to it.

I think we covered a lot of those factors. I'm just curious if there is anything else that you are seeing or that's specific to an OTA platform **that's more nuanced** in how you guys think about it.

Expert 00:19:02

Yeah, we've talked a lot about the AI agents throughout the journey, and I don't know whether this is particularly relevant for you, but I am very involved with a lot of demand generation stuff right now. I can share with you a bit of insight in terms of the sentiment of Airbnb, but also travel tech companies in terms of being very SEO and SEM dependent, and where **AI agents would potentially be very harmful for them** and would be even more valuable because the OTAs are very dependent on someone like Google pre-AI era. Would that be interesting for you?

Client 00:19:33

Yeah, that would be helpful.

Expert 00:19:35

Yeah. I can start sharing, then we can go back and forth on that. If you look at comments from executives in Airbnb, Booking.com, Expedia, Hotels.com, and just for your information as well, for any of these OTAs, at least 40%-50% of their yearly marketing budget, which is in the billions, goes to Google. **The dependence on SEO and SEM is very strong**. What is happening now, the greatest structural business is actually for these OTAs whose competitive advantage is primarily demand aggregation through SEO, SEM, and paid acquisition. What's happening that's now being disintermediated by AI agents, because essentially the AI agent is coming into that middle layer and really breaking down those searches and those discoverability factors.

Where before today you would say, "I go on Google, and I search best hotels in Miami." Obviously the best OTA who has the best price wins because they capture the search. But tomorrow it is like, "Find me the best hotel in Miami for my group of 12, whom there is a small baby and there are some old grandparents, and I need someplace that has a big parking garage because I have three cars coming in." Immediately you are then having the personal agent scrape all these OTAs at once, whereas we could go to Booking.com, Expedia, Airbnb, Agoda, and that means the SEO ranking becomes a lot less important than being machine readable and transaction enabled.

These OTAs now what they are doing is they are coming out and saying they are building a business-to-agent capability. Airbnb is doing it as well, where we are studying agent behavior as an emerging marketing channel. We are looking at protocols such as UCP to connect agents, host suppliers, as well as payments. That's probably one of the biggest factors that why we also came out two weeks ago to say we are building our own AI agent because we recognize that it's a really big thing **that might disrupt the industry** because, as I rightly mentioned, the OTAs do not actually own the hotels.

We are not Marriott, we are not Hilton, we are not Hyatt, we are not the actual hotel or service apartment providers. We are just a demand aggregation factor or demand aggregation platform. We want to make sure that we don't just disappear overnight and remain irrelevant. This is currently one of the biggest, I think, things that are keeping a lot of the travel tech CEOs up when **it comes to AI and the threat of AI on their companies**.

Client 00:22:07

That's helpful. I think it makes sense. I don't have any other questions. This has been helpful for us in our research.

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